

Question ID: b69d821d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	Hard

Question

The following text is Vita Sackville-West’s circa 1920 poem “Evening.” Spars are ships’ masts, moorings are ropes that hold docked ships in place, and a riding-light is a light that a ship shines when it is anchored.

When little lights in little ports come out,

Quivering down through water with the stars,

And all the fishing fleet of slender spars

Range at their moorings, veer with tide about;

When race of wind is stilled and sails are furled,

And underneath our single riding-light

The curve of black-ribbed deck gleams palely white,

And slumbrous waters pool a slumbrous world;

—Then, and then only, have I thought how sweet

Old age might sink upon a windy youth,

Quiet beneath the riding-light of truth,

Weathered through storms, and gracious in retreat.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

Answer

- A. The tranquility of a port in the evening can incline a person to appreciate the stillness of old age.
- B. The difficulty of bringing a ship into port is apt training for dealing with the types of struggles encountered in old age.
- C. A person who leads a long life that is varied and active may find it difficult to stay in a calm place.
- D. The contrast between the peacefulness of a port at night and its activity during the day reflects the contrast between the calm of old age and the vibrancy of youth.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it best states the main idea of the text. The speaker describes an evening scene observed from a boat: "little lights in little ports come out" and are reflected in the water's surface "with the stars," fishing boats are moored, "sails are furled" (rolled up), and the riding-light is shining. The speaker emphasizes the calmness of the scene, noting that the "race of wind is stilled" and the atmosphere is sleepy ("slumbrous waters pool a slumbrous world"), and then indicates that the calmness prompts thoughts of how old age might be "sweet" and "quiet" and "gracious in retreat" after "a windy youth" with "storms." Thus, the main idea is that the tranquility of a port in the evening can lead a person to appreciate the potential stillness of old age.

Choice B is incorrect because the speaker isn't discussing the difficulty of bringing a ship into port but describing the calmness of the port at night. And rather than suggesting that old age involves struggles, the speaker suggests that after "a windy youth" with "storms" to be weathered, old age will be "sweet," "quiet," and "gracious"—that is, old age will be tranquil like a port at night. Choice C is incorrect because the speaker isn't suggesting that a person who has lived a varied and active life might find it difficult to stay in a calm place in old age. On the contrary, the speaker suggests that after a "windy youth" with "storms," old age can be welcomed as something "sweet," "quiet," and "gracious," just like a calm port at night. Choice D is incorrect. Although the speaker does touch on the idea of a "windy youth" followed by "sweet old age," the speaker doesn't tie that idea to a contrast between daytime activity and nighttime peacefulness at a port. The speaker doesn't address any activity during the day at a port, only briefly mentioning that the "race of wind is stilled" at the end of the day, and instead focuses on the tranquility of the port at night and how it prompts thoughts of "quiet" and "gracious" old age.